NEXT STEP · AN EARLY TEST APP

Start your schoolwork, get back to it after a break, ask for what helps, and find friendly people. *You decide each step.*

For teenagers (about 13 to 17) whose brains work differently, for example autistic, ADHD or dyslexic.



An early test version. Every example is made up. It does not diagnose anything.

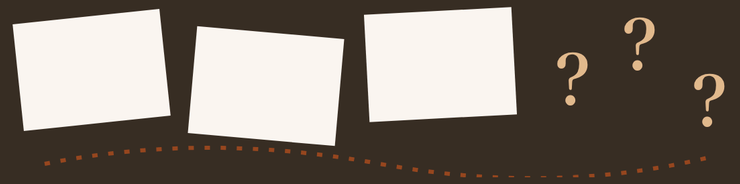
THE SAME HOMEWORK, TWO WAYS

Sam's homework instructions are in three places, and they disagree. *Next Step sorts them into one list.*

TODAY

Sam has an assignment sheet, an email and a class slide. Each gives a different due date.

Sam isn't sure what counts, gets interrupted halfway, and starts over the next day.



WITH NEXT STEP

Sam pastes all three. Each task shows the line it came from.

- [x] **Write a short reflection**
  from the assignment sheet, line 3.
- [x] **Bring one question to the meeting**
  from the email, line 6.
- [ ] **Ask which date applies**
  only "if" the dates clash. Kept for later.

WHERE YOU PAUSED Picked my topic. Stopped before writing.

Sam is a made-up student. This is an illustration, not a real case.

WHAT GOES WRONG

Four times schoolwork gets stuck. *The hard part is the moment, not you.*

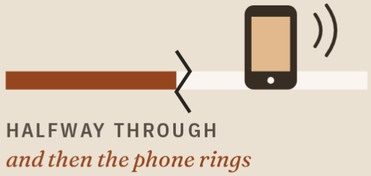


STARTING

You know roughly what to do, but can't start

The first step feels too big. Instructions spread over a handout, an email and a slide make it harder.

So the work never starts, or starts on the wrong thing.



COMING BACK

One interruption wipes out your place

A bell, a message or a break, and the plan in your head is gone.

So coming back feels like starting over.



SAYING WHAT YOU NEED

Explaining yourself, again and again

Each new teacher needs the same explanation, and some people feel they must share a medical label first.

So some people stop asking.



FINDING YOUR PEOPLE

Feeling alone, with nowhere safe online

It can be hard to find friendly people, and big online chats bring strangers and pressure.

So there is no safe place to meet people who like the same things.

And some days you have less energy, so a plan made on a good day can be too much on a hard one.

The next slide shows how we know.

HOW WE KNOW THIS IS REAL

Other people describe these problems too. *1,296 public posts and published studies.*

PROBLEM	FOUND	WHAT PEOPLE DESCRIBE	WHO IT IS ABOUT
Starting	**274** POSTS	Knowing what to do, but not being able to begin. Studies of college students with ADHD also name planning and organising as common barriers.	*Mostly adults*
Coming back	**271** POSTS	Losing your place after an interruption, and struggling to pick up again.	*Mostly adults, often at work*
Saying what you need	**455** POSTS	Asking for changes, often without wanting to name a condition. 370 more posts about being judged.	*Mostly adults at work*
Finding your people	**41** STUDIES	A review found autistic teenagers feel they belong where they are accepted and share interests.	*Autistic teenagers. Nothing yet on online spaces*
Energy	**~300** POSTS	Energy that changes from day to day, and exhaustion from hiding differences.	*Mostly adults*

Public Reddit and LinkedIn posts, mostly adults, ages not checked; one post can count in more than one row. They show the problems are real for some people, not how common they are, or that this app helps. No teenager has used it yet. It started from personal experience.

THE IDEA

One app for all four moments. *You tell it your energy today, and it asks for less on hard days.*

MOMENT 1

Start

Paste instructions, get **small steps you tick**

I'm stuck: four ways out

Find a tiny first step

MOMENT 2

Come back

Pause with a note

Pick up where you left off

What next? when it's done

MOMENT 3

Say what you need

My card in your own words

Ask for a change, you send it yourself

No need to name a condition

MOMENT 4 · TEST ONLY

Find your people

Rooms for **drawing, games, animals, music**

Something to make each week

You can just look

ENERGY TODAY A little Some Plenty On a tired day, it shows just your next step.

Type or talk · your work stays on your phone or computer · nothing happens unless you tap

The next slides show each moment in the working app.

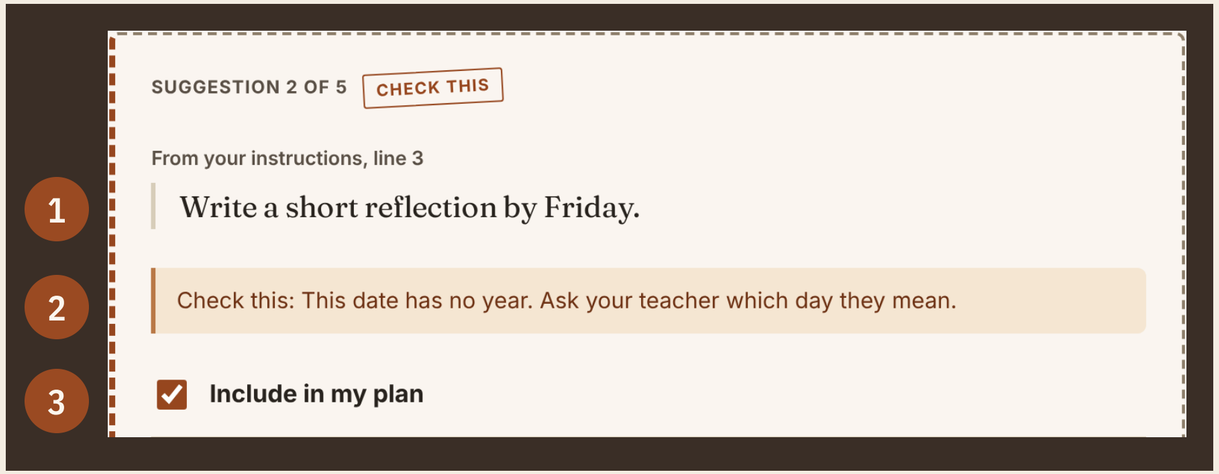
START: CHECK EACH TASK

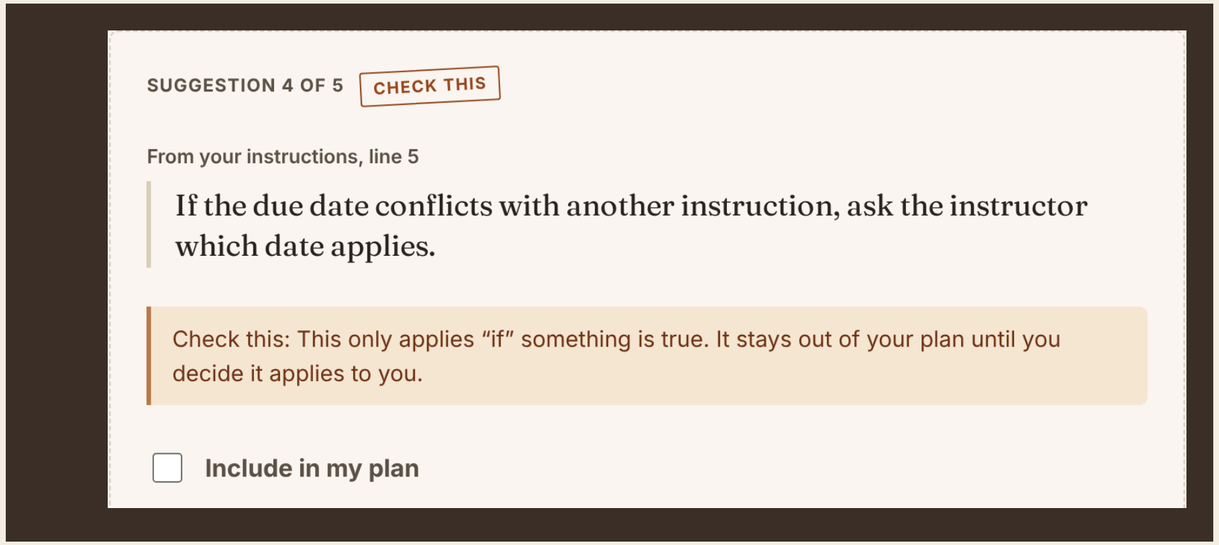
It pulls the tasks out of your instructions, *and warns you when one might be wrong.*

1. **The real words.** Each task shows the exact line it came from.

2. **A warning.** For example: “this date has no year” or “this only matters if…”.

3. **You choose.** Tasks that only apply “if…”, or are optional, start unticked and wait until you decide.

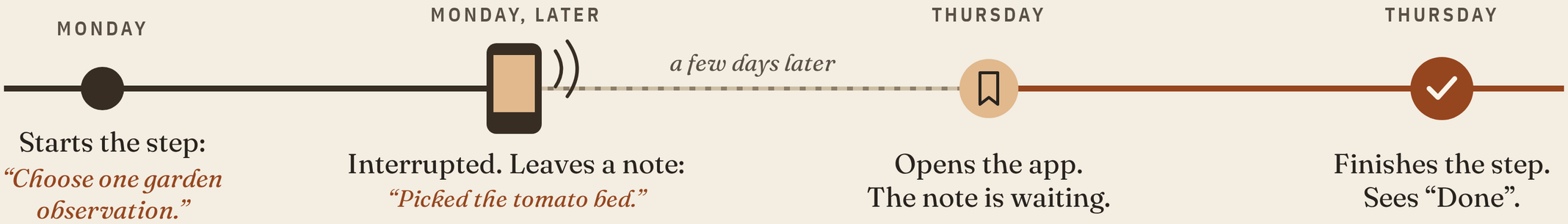


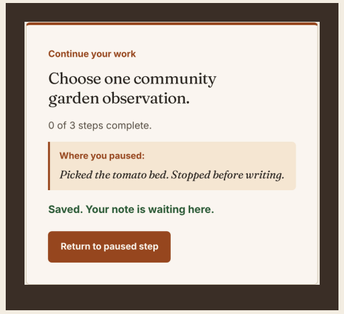


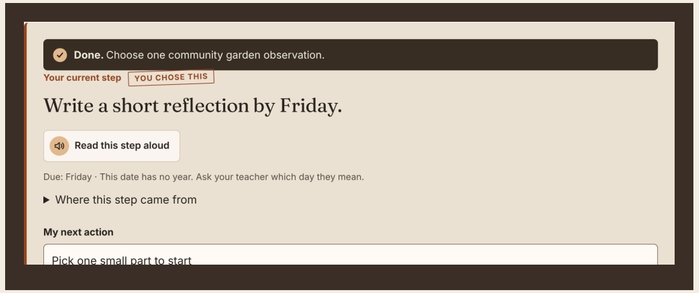
It finds tasks with simple rules on your own phone or computer. AI help is off unless you turn it on.

COME BACK

Take a break without losing your place. *The note you left is waiting.*





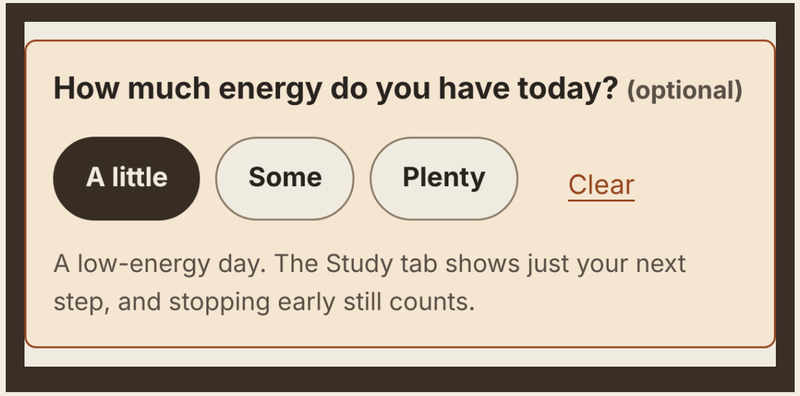


Saved on this phone or computer only. It is not sent anywhere.

Screens from the working app.

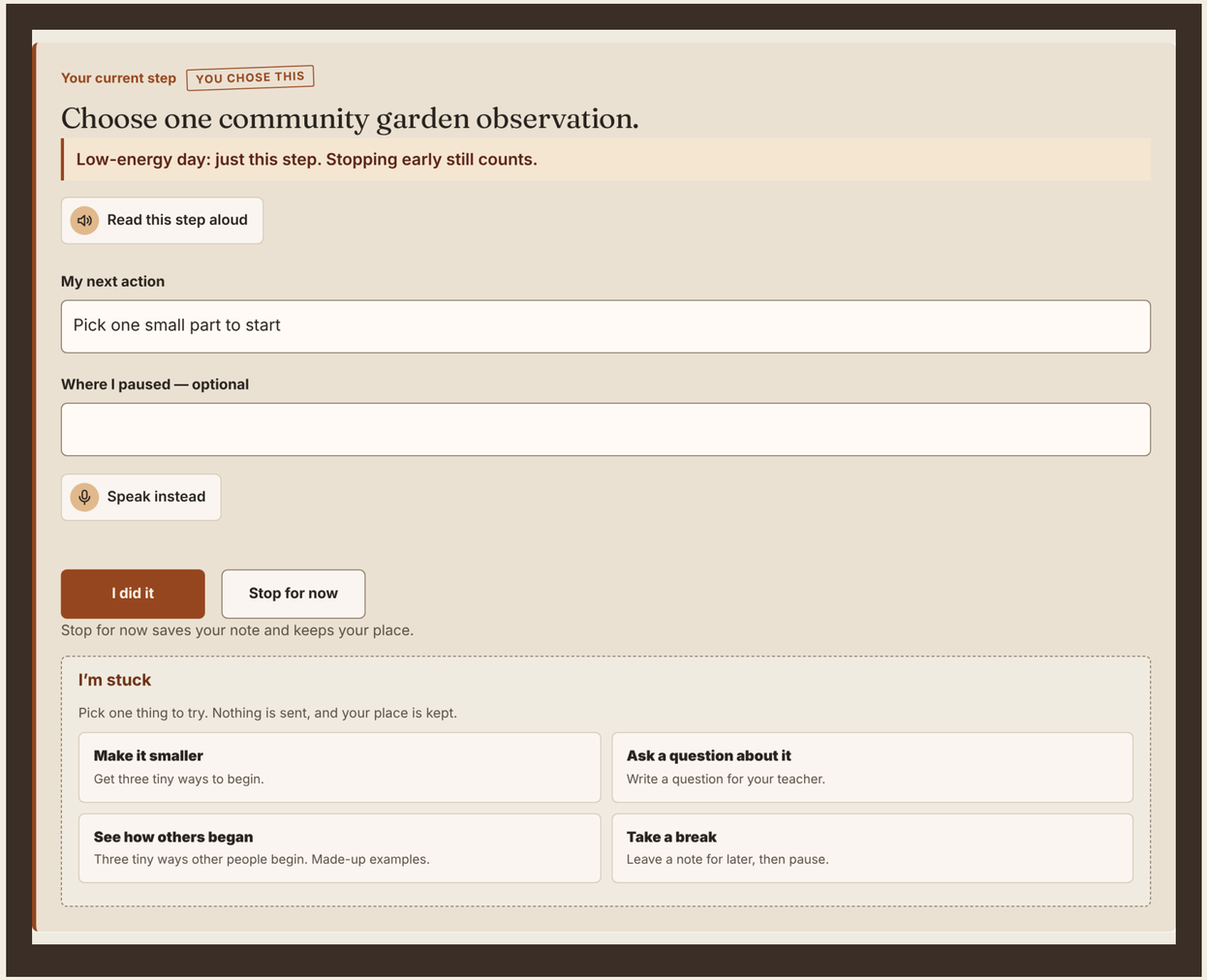
ON A LOW-ENERGY DAY

It asks for less *when you have less.*



A little: only the next step shows. The full list waits.

I'm stuck: make it smaller, write a question for your teacher, see how others began, or take a break.



Your energy choice stays on your phone or computer and resets the next day.

SAY WHAT YOU NEED: MY CARD

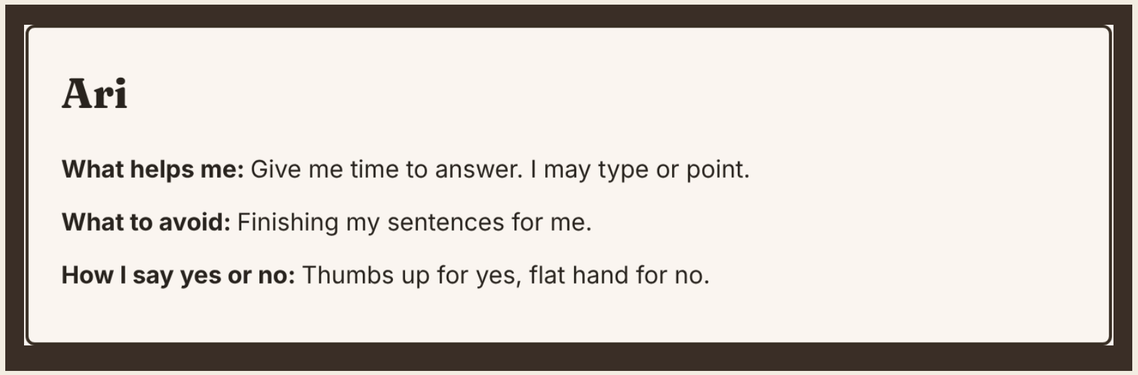
Explain what helps you once, *on a short card in your own words.*

What helps me: for example “Please write down the steps.”

What to avoid: for example “Please do not rush me.”

How I say yes or no: for example “I may nod or point.”

Ready-made lines to tap if you are not sure what to write. You can change every word.



You show it, copy it or print it yourself. Nothing is sent for you.

The card stays on your phone or computer. It is never sent to AI help.

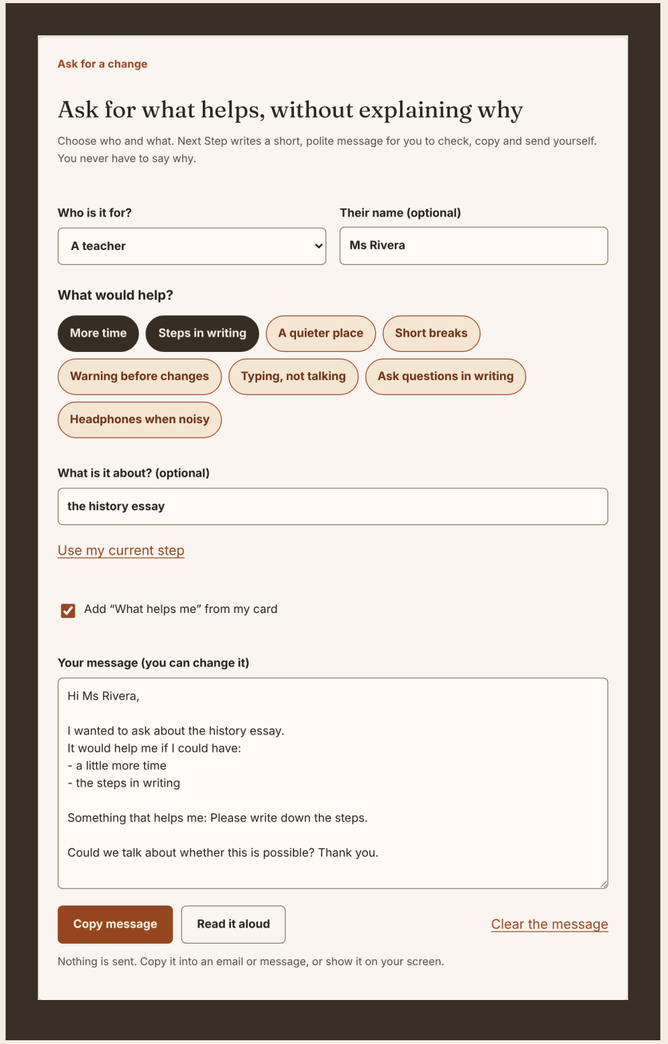
SAY WHAT YOU NEED: ASK A TEACHER

Ask for what helps, *without explaining why.*

Pick who and what. More time, steps in writing, a quiet place, a short break.

It writes a polite message in your name, using the card you made. It does not add any medical label.

Nothing is sent for you. You copy it, read it aloud, or show it on your screen.



In public posts, mostly from adults at work, people often wanted to ask for help without naming a condition.

TYPE OR TALK

Type or talk. *You check the words before anything is added.*

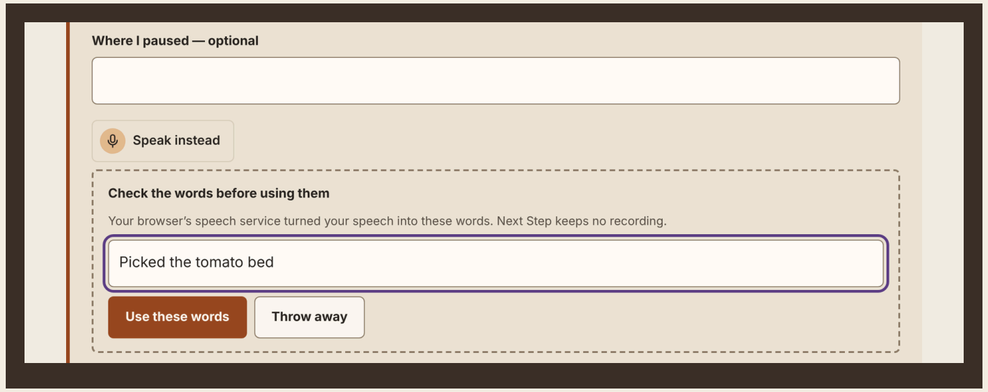
Tap to start
The microphone is off until you tap.

Speak
The screen says “Listening…” the whole time.

See the words
Shown before anything is added.

Fix them
Speech tools mishear. You correct it.

Add, or discard
Your choice. No recording is kept.



You can speak instead of typing almost anywhere, and have your step read aloud. Typing always works too.

Talking needs the internet: your browser’s speech service (for example Google in Chrome) turns your voice into words. Next Step keeps no recording.

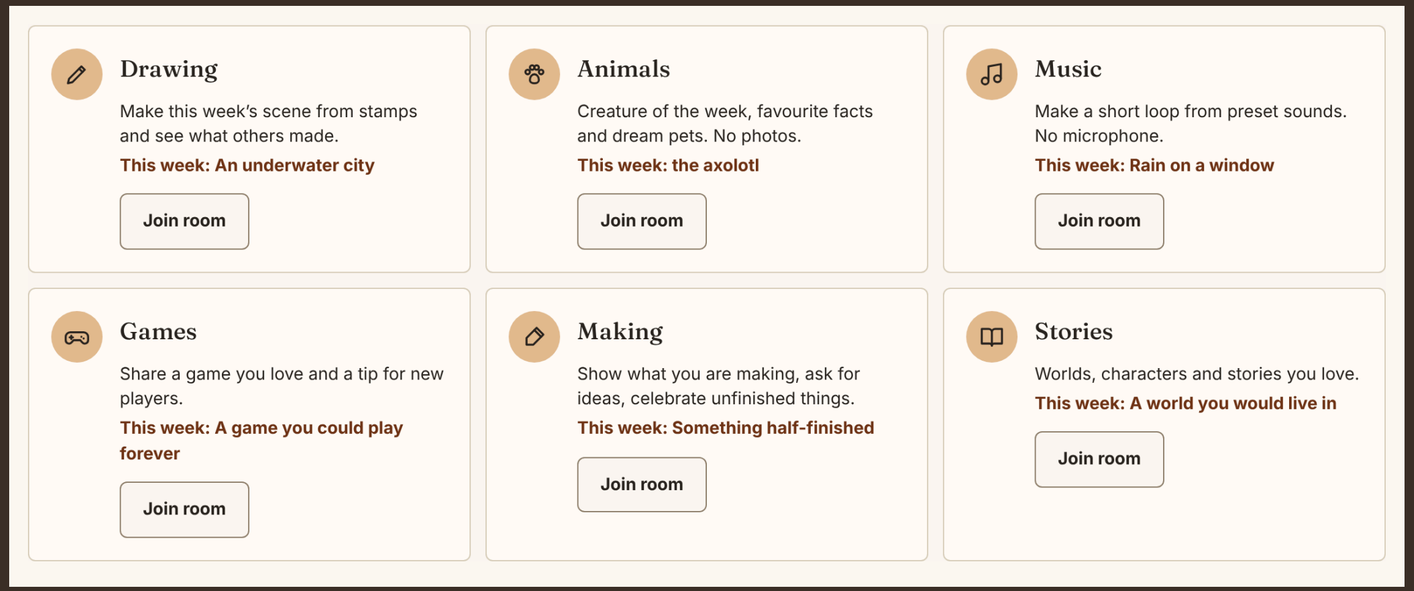
ROOMS FOR WHAT YOU LOVE

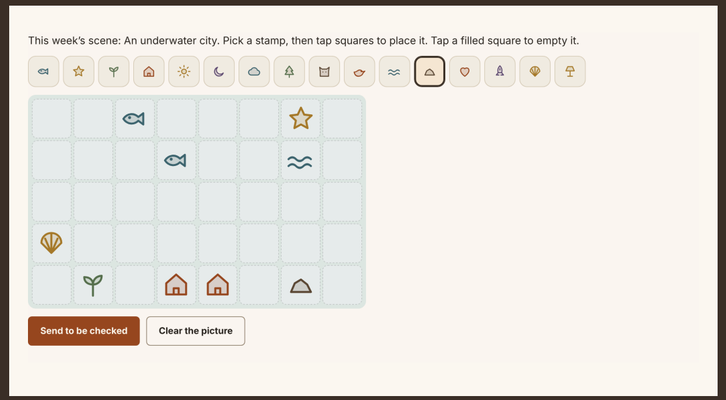
Do what you love, *alongside others.*

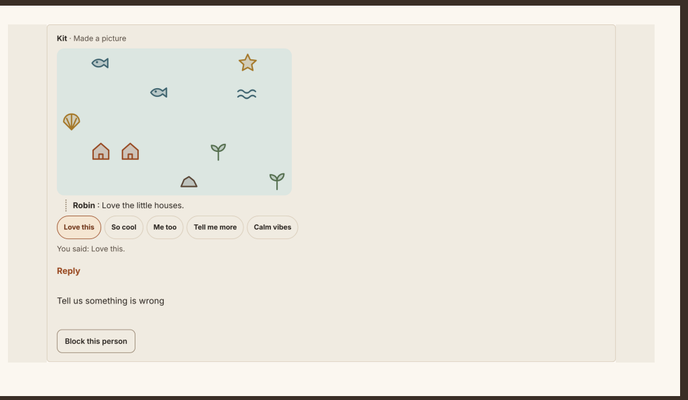
Drawing, games, animals, music, making and stories, each with an idea for the week. You can just look. You never have to post.

Never: private messages, like or follower numbers, photos, voice, or labels about your condition. In real use, a trained adult would check every post first.

PRACTICE: MADE-UP PEOPLE · LIVE TEST: ADULTS ONLY







Studies suggest autistic teens connect more easily through shared hobbies. Before real use: a child-safety lead, trained checkers, a lawyer's review, and teens helping design it.

WHERE YOUR INFORMATION GOES

Your work stays on your phone or computer. *Nothing leaves unless you share it, talk instead of type, or turn on AI help.*



Practice rooms stay on your device. A live test version lets adults try the rooms; its sign-in, age and parent checks are pretend, so it is not for real teenagers yet.

NOT KNOWN YET

What we don’t know yet. *Said plainly.*

That it helps people

No study with people has been run yet.

Screen readers

Built to follow accessibility rules for apps that read the screen aloud. Not yet tried by people who use them.

Rooms and activities

Built on research about shared interests. Not yet tried with young people.

Who would pay

How many people need it, and would pay, is unknown.

Phone apps

Android and iPhone versions exist. Not yet tried on real phones.

Room safety

Designed, but not yet run with real checkers or real members.

Next: pay teenagers to help shape it, then a careful study approved by an ethics board.

WHAT THE TESTS CHECK

You can open it on the web today. *It is checked by computer tests, not yet by people.*

625
of 637 small computer tests pass. Each one is a small automatic check of the app.

10
everyday journeys clicked all the way through by the computer, with no errors

5
screen setups, simulated: phone, small phone, laptop, biggest text, keyboard only

0
real teenagers have tried it so far. That comes next.

637 tests: 625 pass, 12 fail.



The tests cover all four moments, voice, the rooms and working without internet.

12 fail: they need files from other build steps or another computer

Also tested: it works without the internet after the first visit, you can save a copy or wipe your data, and your pause note survives closing the page.

WHAT WE ASK

Help us test it with the people *it's for.*

1

Your view

Are these the right four problems? What would you change? Two minutes, no sign-up, at the feedback link.

2

A careful first study

People who check research is safe, and disability experts, to help plan a small study.

3

Design it with teens

Teenagers who think differently, paid for their time, and youth-club leaders, to shape the rooms.

TRY IT NOW

mehtama1234.github.io/
neuro-divergent

Live rooms (public test):
next-step-live.onrender.com

Tell us what you think:
next-step-live.onrender.com/feedback

Made by Amishi Mehta. Next: paid sessions with teenagers, then a careful study approved by an ethics board. Every example in the app is made up.